A PRACTICAL GUIDE FOR CONTENT TEACHERS



Using Spanish to Teach Spanish-Speaking English Learners in the Content Classroom

Research-based strategies for math, science, social studies, and ELA teachers in grades 9–12 — no fluency required

energy · energía equation · ecuación history · historia metaphor · metáfora evidence · evidencia

Richard A. Daniel
ENL Teacher · Laurel High School · Laurel, Mississippi

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Research-based strategies for math, science, social studies, and ELA teachers—no Spanish fluency required

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About this guide. This guide was written for the general content faculty of Laurel High School. It may be freely copied and shared for professional learning within the school and district. Research is cited throughout; full references appear at the end. Spanish phrases reflect widely understood Latin American usage; vocabulary can vary by country, so welcome your students' versions.

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BEFORE WE BEGIN

A Note from Richard A. Daniel

Dear colleagues,

If you teach at Laurel High School, you already know that Spanish is part of the sound of our building. You hear it in the hallways, at lunch, in the parking lot at pickup, and—if you listen closely—in your own classroom when two students quietly check with each other about what an assignment means. About 262 of our 748 students are Hispanic, roughly one in three. Many of them are English learners, and many of those learners carry a resource into your room every single day that is easy to overlook: a strong, living home language.

This guide is for teachers who do not speak Spanish. You do not need to be fluent to use Spanish as a tool for learning. You do not need to translate your lessons. You do not need to become a language teacher. What you need is a handful of research-backed routines, a few dozen words and phrases, and a willingness to let students use everything they know to learn your content.

Most of the English learners you teach are at the **Emerging** or **Progressing** levels on the ELPA21 assessment. Many of them have been in U.S. schools for more than five years. They talk easily in Spanish—and often in social English—but academic reading and writing in English are still hard work. A smaller group are newcomers who arrived recently and speak only Spanish (or, in some cases, an Indigenous language plus some Spanish). These two groups need different things from us, and this guide will help you tell the difference.

Every strategy here is something you can try next week. Each chapter ends with a short set of reflection questions you can use on your own, with a department, or in a PLC. Near the end you will find a sample lesson for math, science, social studies, and ELA, plus a one-page quick-reference you can print and keep on your desk.

Thank you for the work you already do for our students. My door is always open—come find me if you want to plan a lesson together, borrow materials, or just talk through a student you are worried about.

Con gratitud (with gratitude),

Richard A. Daniel

ENL Teacher, Laurel High School

> TIP · **How to use this guide**
>
> - **Short on time?** Read Chapter 1, skim Chapter 3 for your subject's cognate list, and print the Quick Reference.
> - **Planning a unit?** Start with your subject's lesson snapshot in Chapter 11 and borrow its structure.
> - **Working with a PLC?** Use the reflection questions at the end of each chapter as discussion prompts.

CHAPTER 1

Why Spanish Belongs in Your Classroom

What the research says about the home language and learning

The big idea

When a student who is still learning English sits in your Biology or Algebra I class, they are doing two jobs at once: learning the content and learning the language the content is taught in. For decades, many schools assumed the best way to help was to keep the home language out of the room so students would "think in English" faster. Research on bilingual learners points in a different direction. A student's first language is not an obstacle to learning English; it is one of the best tools available for learning English *and* learning content.

This does not mean teaching in Spanish. It means **inviting students to use Spanish strategically**—to think, plan, discuss, check understanding, and connect new ideas to what they already know—while you continue to teach in English and hold high expectations for English output.

Cummins: transfer and common underlying proficiency

Jim Cummins, one of the most cited researchers in bilingual education, has argued for decades that the knowledge and skills a student develops in one language are not locked inside that language. In *Negotiating Identities: Education for Empowerment in a Diverse Society* (2001), Cummins describes a **common underlying proficiency**: the concepts, thinking skills, and literacy strategies a person develops in one language become part of a shared foundation that supports the other language.

Cummins often uses the image of an iceberg (sometimes drawn as a "dual iceberg"). Above the waterline, Spanish and English look like two separate languages, with different words, sounds, and grammar. Below the waterline, they share a single base of understanding. A student who already understands what a *fracción* is, how photosynthesis works, or how to find the main idea of a text does not need to relearn the concept in English—they need the English words and structures to express what they already know.

> RESEARCH NOTE · **What "transfer" looks like in your room**
>
> - A student who learned to solve proportions in Mexico or Guatemala can apply that skill in your class once they can read the word problem.
> - A student who knows how to summarize a story in Spanish can use the same mental moves to summarize an English text.
> - A student who knows the Spanish word *energía* can quickly attach meaning to the English word *energy*.
>
> Transfer is not automatic. It happens more reliably when teachers make the connections between languages visible and explicit.

Cummins also emphasizes that how schools treat a student's language sends a message about how they value the student. In the same book, he argues that classroom interactions either affirm or diminish students' identities, and that affirming identity is linked to academic engagement. When a student hears a teacher say "You can use Spanish to plan this—your Spanish is an asset here," the message is not only practical but personal.

Moll and colleagues: funds of knowledge

In 1992, Luis Moll, Cathy Amanti, Deborah Neff, and Norma González published "Funds of Knowledge for Teaching: Using a Qualitative Approach to Connect Homes and Classrooms" in the journal *Theory Into Practice*. Working with teachers in Mexican American households in Tucson, Arizona, they documented the rich, historically developed bodies of knowledge families use to get through daily life—knowledge about things like construction, agriculture, mechanics, cooking, medicine, business, and caring for others.

Their central point is that students from working-class and immigrant families arrive at school with far more knowledge than schools typically recognize. When teachers learn about these **funds of knowledge** and build lessons that connect to them, students can see their families' expertise reflected in academic work. Much of that knowledge lives in Spanish. A student who has helped a relative frame a house, run a food stand, or manage a household budget brings real-world understanding of measurement, ratio, chemistry, economics, and persuasion—often with Spanish vocabulary attached.

TRY THIS · **Try this: a two-minute funds-of-knowledge check**

On an index card, ask students (in English and Spanish):

- *What is something you know how to do really well? / ¿Qué es algo que sabes hacer muy bien?*
- *What does someone in your family know a lot about? / ¿De qué sabe mucho alguien de tu familia?*

Keep the cards. When you plan a unit, flip through them and look for connections.

García: translanguaging

Ofelia García and her colleagues use the term **translanguaging** to describe how bilingual people actually use language: not as two separate boxes they switch between, but as one connected repertoire they draw on to make meaning. In *Translanguaging: Language, Bilingualism and Education* (García & Li Wei, 2014) and *The Translanguaging Classroom: Leveraging Student Bilingualism for Learning* (García, Johnson, & Seltzer, 2017), they describe classrooms where teachers—including teachers who do not speak students' languages—intentionally design opportunities for students to use all of their language resources.

A translanguaging approach does not lower the bar for English. Instead, it treats the home language as a scaffold *toward* rigorous content and English. García, Johnson, and Seltzer describe a "translanguaging stance" (a belief that students' full linguistic repertoire is a resource), "design" (planning lessons and assessments that strategically integrate home language), and "shifts" (the moment-to-moment choices a teacher makes in response to students). You can take a translanguaging stance whether or not you speak a word of Spanish.

RESEARCH NOTE · **Teachers who don't speak the language can do this**

The CUNY-NYSIEB guide *Translanguaging: A CUNY-NYSIEB Guide for Educators* (Celic & Seltzer, 2011) was written for exactly this situation: classrooms where teachers often do not share students' home languages. It offers practical strategies such as home-language partner talk, multilingual word walls, and preview-view-review, many of which appear in this book.

What about cognates?

Because English and Spanish share a large stock of words that came from Latin and Greek, Spanish speakers have a special advantage with **academic** English. Lubliner and Hiebert (2011) analyzed two widely used word lists and found a substantial number of English–Spanish cognates in both. They identified 426 cognates among the 570 headwords of the Academic Word List—the words that show up across content-area textbooks. That is roughly

three out of every four. They concluded that carefully designed cognate instruction may give Spanish-speaking students a "cognate advantage" with academic texts. Earlier, Nagy, García, Durgunoğlu, and Hancin-Bhatt (1993) found that Spanish–English bilingual students' ability to recognize cognates was related to their English reading comprehension—but that students did not always notice cognates on their own. In other words: the bridge exists, but we have to point it out. Chapter 3 shows you how.

The broader research base

The National Literacy Panel on Language-Minority Children and Youth, whose report was edited by Diane August and Timothy Shanahan (2006), reviewed research on how English learners develop literacy. One of the panel's conclusions was that certain aspects of first-language literacy and oral proficiency can be used to support literacy development in English. That finding is consistent with Cummins's idea of transfer.

The legal and ethical floor

Using a student's home language is not only good pedagogy; meaningful access is a civil-rights obligation. In *Lau v. Nichols* (1974), the U.S. Supreme Court held that providing non-English-speaking students with the same books, teachers, and curriculum—without help understanding them—did not give them equal educational opportunity. In 2015, the U.S. Department of Justice and the U.S. Department of Education issued joint guidance (*English Learner Students and Limited English Proficient Parents*) reminding schools that English learners must be able to participate meaningfully in all programs and that schools must communicate with parents in a language they can understand.

> SPANISH CORNER · **A word on terms**
>
> This guide uses **English learner (EL)** because it matches ELPA21 and state reporting. You will also see **emergent bilingual** in research by García and others; that term emphasizes what students are becoming—bilingual—rather than what they lack. Both are in common use.

What this means for you

- Spanish in your classroom is a **tool for learning**, not a distraction from it.
- You do not have to speak Spanish to **invite** Spanish.
- Students' knowledge—from school back home, from their families, from their lives—**transfers** when we make connections visible.
- English remains the goal for final products in most tasks, and Spanish is one of the fastest routes to get there.

> PAUSE & REFLECT · **Questions for reflection**
>
> 1. When have you seen a student use Spanish in your class? What was the student doing with it—avoiding work, or making sense of it? How do you know?
> 2. What messages (spoken or unspoken) does your classroom currently send about Spanish?
> 3. Which of your units has the strongest connection to knowledge students might bring from home?

CHAPTER 2

Knowing Your Learners

Long-term English learners, newcomers, and everyone in between

ELPA21 levels at a glance

Mississippi uses the ELPA21 assessment to measure English language proficiency in four domains: listening, speaking, reading, and writing. ELPA21 reports an overall proficiency determination of **Emerging**, **Progressing**, or **Proficient**. Most of the English learners in our content classes are Emerging or Progressing.

Level	What you may notice	What helps most
Emerging	Understands simple, familiar English, especially with visuals; speaks in words or short phrases; reads and writes with heavy support.	Visuals, gestures, Spanish previews, bilingual glossaries, word banks, a Spanish-speaking partner, sentence frames for every response.
Progressing	Follows much of class talk; participates in discussions; reads grade-level text with difficulty; writing shows ideas but limited academic vocabulary and sentence variety.	Cognate instruction, academic sentence frames, structured talk before writing, explicit vocabulary teaching, models of strong writing.
Proficient	Handles most grade-level academic English with typical support.	Continued attention to academic vocabulary and writing; monitoring after exit from services.

Check with the ENL teacher for each student's most recent domain scores. ELPA21 also reports a level from 1 to 5 in each domain, so a student who is Progressing overall may score high in listening and speaking but much lower in writing. That pattern is very common—and very important for how you plan.

Long-term English learners (LTELs)

Many of our English learners have been in U.S. schools for more than five years—some since kindergarten—and have not yet reached English proficiency. Researchers and policymakers often call these students **long-term English learners**. Definitions vary from state to state and study to study; many use a threshold of six or more years in U.S. schools. Laurie Olsen's report *Reparable Harm* (2010) and work by Kate Menken and Tatyana Kleyn (2010) describe common patterns among these students:

- They often sound fluent in social English, so teachers may not realize they are English learners.
- Their academic reading and writing in English lag behind their oral English.
- Many were schooled only in English, so their Spanish is strong **orally** but they may have had few chances to read and write academically in Spanish. Menken and Kleyn describe this as the result of "subtractive schooling."
- Many have experienced inconsistent language support across years and schools.
- Some feel discouraged or labeled; being an "EL" in high school can feel like a stigma.

CAUTION · **Don't assume Spanish literacy**

A long-term EL may speak Spanish fluently at home and with friends but find a Spanish textbook paragraph as challenging as an English one. For LTELs, the most powerful use of Spanish is usually **oral**: discussion, brainstorming, and explaining thinking to a partner. Ask students what works for them—don't assume.

Newcomers

A smaller number of our students are **newcomers**—students who have recently arrived in the United States and are at the very beginning of learning English. Newcomers vary widely:

- **Students with strong prior schooling** may read and write well in Spanish and may know the content (for example, algebra or biology) better than some of their classmates. For them, Spanish materials and bilingual glossaries can unlock grade-level content right away.
- **Students with limited or interrupted formal education** (often abbreviated SIFE or SLIFE) may have missed significant schooling. They need content support *and* foundational literacy support, and Spanish texts may not help if they are still developing literacy in any language.
- **Students who speak an Indigenous language.** Some families from Guatemala, Mexico, and elsewhere speak an Indigenous language at home (for example, a Mayan language such as K'iche', Mam, or Q'anjob'al). For these students, Spanish may be a second language—and English a third. Ask; never assume.

Newcomers also may be adjusting to a new country, family separation or reunification, new routines, and sometimes trauma. Predictable routines, a welcoming peer partner, and a teacher who greets them by name (pronounced correctly) matter enormously.

Side by side

	Long-term EL (5+ years in U.S. schools)	Newcomer (recently arrived)
Oral English	Often fluent socially	Beginning
Academic English	Still developing, especially writing	Beginning
Spanish	Strong orally; academic Spanish literacy varies, often limited	Often strong orally; literacy depends on prior schooling
Best uses of Spanish	Talk before writing; cognates; checking understanding with a partner; reflecting on language differences	Previews; bilingual glossaries; Spanish texts or videos on the topic; a bilingual partner; responding in Spanish to show content knowledge
Watch out for	Assuming they don't need support because they "sound fluent"; letting Spanish become a way to avoid English writing	Isolating them; making them sit silently; giving only translated worksheets with no English exposure
Motivation keys	Respect, rigor, relevance, a sense of progress toward exiting EL status	Belonging, safety, visible small wins, a buddy

Get to know each student

Labels help us plan, but every student is an individual. A brief, low-stakes language survey at the start of the year (or when a student enrolls) can tell you a lot. Offer it in English and Spanish.

TRY THIS · **A five-question language survey**

- What language(s) do you speak at home? / *¿Qué idioma(s) hablas en casa?*
- Can you read and write in Spanish? A little, some, or a lot? / *¿Puedes leer y escribir en español? ¿Un poco, algo o mucho?*
- Where did you go to school before Laurel High? / *¿Dónde estudiaste antes de Laurel High?*
- What helps you learn best in class? / *¿Qué te ayuda a aprender mejor en clase?*
- What do you want me to know about you? / *¿Qué quieres que yo sepa de ti?*

PAUSE & REFLECT · **Questions for reflection**

1. Which of your current students might be long-term ELs who "sound fluent" but struggle with academic writing? What evidence do you have?
2. What do you know about the prior schooling and home languages of the newcomers you teach? How could you find out more?
3. How might a long-term EL feel about being labeled an English learner in high school? How can your classroom reduce that stigma?

CHAPTER 3

Cognates: Your Built-In Bridge

The fastest vocabulary win for Spanish speakers

What cognates are

Cognates are words in two languages that share a common origin and have similar spelling, sound, and meaning: *biology / biología*, *democracy / democracia*, *equation / ecuación*. Because so much academic English comes from Latin and Greek, the "hard" words in your textbook are often the *easy* words for a Spanish speaker. A word like *photosynthesis* can feel intimidating to an English-only student, while a Spanish speaker may recognize *fotosíntesis* right away.

There is a twist. Many academic English words are **everyday** words in Spanish. Lubliner and Hiebert (2011) found that most Academic Word List cognates are more common in Spanish than in English. An English speaker might say a story has a *tricky* ending; a Spanish speaker might naturally say *complicado* (complicated). Your Spanish speakers may already own the sophisticated version of the word.

> CAUTION · **Students won't always notice cognates by themselves**
>
> Nagy and colleagues (1993) found that bilingual students did not consistently recognize cognates without instruction. Some long-term ELs have never been told that their Spanish can help them in English class. Teach the strategy out loud: *"Does this word look like a word you know in Spanish?"*

Spelling patterns that unlock hundreds of words

Teach students a few predictable patterns. Post them in your room.

English pattern	Spanish pattern	Examples
-tion	-ción	nation / nación, solution / solución, revolution / revolución
-ty	-dad / -tad	gravity / gravedad, density / densidad, liberty / libertad
-ous	-oso / -osa	famous / famoso, numerous / numeroso
-ic, -ical	-ico / -ica	scientific / científico, historic / histórico
-ly	-mente	rapidly / rápidamente, finally / finalmente
-ize	-izar	analyze / analizar, organize / organizar
-ive	-ivo / -iva	positive / positivo, persuasive / persuasivo
-ist, -ism	-ista, -ismo	artist / artista, capitalism / capitalismo
s + consonant	es + consonant	structure / estructura, species / especie, state / estado
ph, th	f, t	photosynthesis / fotosíntesis, theory / teoría

Not every word follows the pattern perfectly—*scientist* is *científico* in Spanish, not *cientista*—which is a good reason to treat patterns as clues, not rules.

A five-minute cognate routine

1. **Spot.** Before a reading, ask partners to skim and highlight words that look like Spanish words.
2. **Say.** Students say the Spanish word aloud. (You don't have to; let them teach you.)
3. **Check.** Partners decide: same meaning, or a false cognate? Use context to check.
4. **Sort.** Add true cognates to the word wall in two colors (English in one color, Spanish in another).
5. **Use.** Require at least two new academic words in the exit ticket.

Subject-specific cognate lists

These lists focus on high-frequency academic vocabulary in grades 9–12. Spanish accents matter—students who learned to write in Spanish will notice—so copy them carefully.

Mathematics

English	Spanish	English	Spanish
algebra	álgebra	perimeter	perímetro
angle	ángulo	perpendicular	perpendicular
area	área	polygon	polígono
coefficient	coeficiente	polynomial	polinomio
congruent	congruente	probability	probabilidad
constant	constante	proportion	proporción
coordinate	coordenada	quadratic	cuadrático
diameter	diámetro	radius	radio
equation	ecuación	rectangle	rectángulo
equivalent	equivalente	sequence	secuencia
exponent	exponente	simplify	simplificar
expression	expresión	symmetry	simetría
fraction	fracción	theorem	teorema
function	función	triangle	triángulo
hypotenuse	hipotenusa	variable	variable
linear	lineal	vertex	vértice
parallel	paralelo	volume	volumen

> SPANISH CORNER · **Math words that are NOT cognates (worth pre-teaching)**
>
> **slope** = *pendiente* · **average / mean** = *promedio / media* · **integer** = *número entero* · **inequality** = *desigualdad* · **square root** = *raíz cuadrada* · **greater than / less than** = *mayor que / menor que* · **ratio** = *razón* · **graph** = *gráfica* (a near-cognate)

Science

English	Spanish	English	Spanish
acceleration	aceleración	gravity	gravedad

English	Spanish	English	Spanish
adaptation	adaptación	hypothesis	hipótesis
atom	átomo	mass	masa
bacteria	bacterias	mineral	mineral
chemical	químico	molecule	molécula
chromosome	cromosoma	nucleus	núcleo
classify	clasificar	observe	observar
conclusion	conclusión	organism	organismo
density	densidad	photosynthesis	fotosíntesis
ecosystem	ecosistema	protein	proteína
electricity	electricidad	reaction	reacción
element	elemento	species	especie
energy	energía	temperature	temperatura
evolution	evolución	theory	teoría
experiment	experimento	variable	variable
gene	gen	velocity	velocidad

Social Studies

English	Spanish	English	Spanish
agriculture	agricultura	immigration	inmigración
capitalism	capitalismo	imperialism	imperialismo
civilization	civilización	independence	independencia
colony	colonia	industry	industria
conflict	conflicto	justice	justicia
constitution	constitución	legislature	legislatura
culture	cultura	liberty	libertad
democracy	democracia	migration	migración
discrimination	discriminación	movement	movimiento
document	documento	population	población
economy	economía	president	presidente
federal	federal	reconstruction	reconstrucción
geography	geografía	region	región
history	historia	republic	república

SPANISH CORNER · **Social studies terms worth pre-teaching**

civil rights = *derechos civiles* · **citizen** = *ciudadano/ciudadana* · **amendment** = *enmienda* · **slavery** = *esclavitud* · **primary source** = *fuente primaria* · **government** = *gobierno* (a near-cognate) · **treaty** = *tratado*

English Language Arts

English	Spanish	English	Spanish
alliteration	aliteración	inference	inferencia
analysis	análisis	introduction	introducción
antagonist	antagonista	irony	ironía
author	autor	metaphor	metáfora
autobiography	autobiografía	narrator	narrador
biography	biografía	novel	novela
climax	clímax	paragraph	párrafo
conclusion	conclusión	perspective	perspectiva
conflict	conflicto	poem	poema
context	contexto	protagonist	protagonista
dialogue	diálogo	simile	símil
evidence	evidencia	structure	estructura
fiction	ficción	symbol	símbolo
tragedy	tragedia	theme	tema

False cognates ("false friends")

Some words look alike but mean different things. These **false cognates** cause real confusion—and they are also great conversation starters. Students love catching them.

English word	Spanish look-alike	What the Spanish word actually means
character (in a story)	carácter	personality or temperament; a story character is *personaje*
argument	argumento	in literature, often the **plot** of a story; also a line of reasoning. A quarrel is *discusión* or *pelea*
discussion	discusión	often an **argument or quarrel**, not just a conversation
lecture	lectura	a **reading**; a lecture is *conferencia* or *clase*
realize	realizar	to **carry out** or accomplish; "to realize" is *darse cuenta*
actual / actually	actual / actualmente	**current / currently**; "actually" is *en realidad*
assist	asistir	to **attend**; "to assist" is *ayudar*
compromise	compromiso	usually a **commitment** or obligation; a compromise is *acuerdo mutuo* or *término medio*
cell (biology)	celda	a **jail cell** or spreadsheet cell; a living cell is *célula*
billion	billón	in Spanish, *un billón* = a million millions (an English **trillion**); a billion is *mil millones*
library	librería	**bookstore**; a library is *biblioteca*
exit	éxito	**success**; an exit is *salida*
large	largo	**long**; large is *grande*
parent	pariente	a **relative** of any kind; parents are *padres*
embarrassed	embarazada	**pregnant**; embarrassed is *avergonzado/a* or *apenado/a*

English word	Spanish look-alike	What the Spanish word actually means
molest	molestar	to **bother** or annoy—so a student saying "he's molesting me" may simply mean "he's bothering me"

CAUTION · **Math alert: numbers are written differently in some countries**

In many Spanish-speaking countries (for example, Spain, Colombia, and Argentina) a **comma** marks the decimal and a **period** separates thousands: *3,5* means 3.5 and *1.000* means one thousand. Mexico and much of Central America generally use the same convention as the U.S. If a student writes 3,5, they may not be making an error. Ask, and teach the U.S. convention explicitly. The written layout for long division also often looks different in Latin American schooling—invite students to show their method.

PAUSE & REFLECT · **Questions for reflection**

1. Look at the vocabulary list for your next unit. What percentage of the words are Spanish cognates? Which are not and will need extra support?
2. Which false cognate is most likely to cause a misunderstanding in your subject?
3. How will you make cognates visible in your room (word wall colors, a poster, a routine)?

CHAPTER 4

Making Spanish Visible

Bilingual word walls and student-made glossaries

Why visible language matters

Walls teach. A room where Spanish appears alongside English tells students, before you say a word, that their language belongs here. It also gives them a reference they can glance at during independent work—especially newcomers who cannot yet ask for help in English.

Building a bilingual word wall

- **Keep it unit-based.** Post 10–20 key terms for the current unit, not every word of the year. Rotate them.
- **Color-code.** Use one color for English and another for Spanish (for example, blue for English, green for Spanish). Use a star or symbol for cognates and a different symbol for false cognates.
- **Add a visual.** A quick sketch, diagram, or photo beside each word helps every learner, including students who speak an Indigenous language.
- **Let students build it.** Assign each pair one word. They write the English, the Spanish, a picture, and a sentence. You check the content; a bilingual student or the ENL teacher can check the Spanish.
- **Use it actively.** Point to it while you teach. Ask, "Which word wall word fits here?" A word wall nobody uses is just decoration.

TRY THIS · **Word wall card template**

Front (large): ENGLISH WORD — *palabra en español* · ★ if a cognate

Back or underneath: a picture · a student-written sentence in English · (optional) the same sentence in Spanish

Student-made bilingual glossaries

A personal glossary is a notebook section or a folded sheet where each student records key terms for the unit. Unlike a teacher-made list, a student-made glossary forces students to process the word.

English term	Spanish	My explanation (any language)	Picture or example
density	densidad	how much stuff is packed into a space	(drawing of crowded vs. spread-out dots)

Tips for glossaries:

- Let students write explanations in **any language**. The goal is understanding; English output comes later in the lesson.
- For newcomers with strong Spanish literacy, a published bilingual glossary can jump-start the process. Some states have produced free content-area glossaries for English learners (New York State's bilingual glossaries are one widely used example); ask the ENL teacher what is available.

- For long-term ELs, emphasize the **English explanation** column over time, since academic English writing is their main growth area.
- Allow glossaries as a reference on classwork and, where appropriate, on quizzes (see Chapter 7).

PAUSE & REFLECT · **Questions for reflection**

1. What would a visitor learn about your classroom's attitude toward language just by looking at your walls?
2. Which five words from your current unit would you put on a bilingual word wall first? Why those?
3. How could students—not you—do most of the work of building and maintaining the wall?

CHAPTER 5

Talk in Spanish, Write in English

Structured talk, preview-view-review, pairing, and sentence frames

Think and talk in Spanish, produce in English

This is the most powerful and simplest move in this guide. For many English learners, especially long-term ELs, the problem is not ideas—it is getting ideas into academic English. When students must think, discuss, and write all in English at once, the cognitive load is enormous. When they can **think and talk first in Spanish**, they arrive at the writing stage with ideas already organized. Then your job becomes helping them express those ideas in English.

TRY THIS · **The routine: Talk → Plan → Write**

1. **Talk (any language).** Partners discuss the question for 2–3 minutes in Spanish, English, or both.
2. **Plan (any language).** Each student jots key ideas or a quick outline—Spanish words allowed.
3. **Write (English).** Students write their response in English, using a sentence frame and the word wall.
4. **Share (English).** One partner reads their English response aloud.

How to introduce it: *"In this class, you can use Spanish to think and talk about ideas. Your final answer will be in English. Spanish helps you get there."* Saying this out loud matters, because many students have been told in past classrooms that Spanish is not allowed.

CAUTION · **Keep the English output real**

The point of talking in Spanish is to make the English product stronger, not to replace it. Hold students accountable for the English step. If a pair's written English is consistently weaker than their discussion, shorten the talk time and add more frames or a model.

Preview-View-Review

Preview-View-Review is a classic strategy described by Yvonne and David Freeman (2007) for using the home language to make English instruction more comprehensible. It has three parts:

Phase	What happens	How you can do it without speaking Spanish
Preview (Spanish)	Students get an overview of the topic in Spanish to build background knowledge.	Show a short Spanish-language video on the topic; give a one-paragraph Spanish summary (prepared with help from the ENL teacher or checked translation); have same-language groups brainstorm what they already know.
View (English)	You teach the lesson in English, making input comprehensible.	Teach as usual, with visuals, demonstrations, gestures, and the word wall. Point out cognates.

Phase	What happens	How you can do it without speaking Spanish
Review (Spanish → English)	Students summarize and clarify in Spanish, then report back in English.	Partners explain the key idea to each other in Spanish, then complete an English exit ticket with a frame.

The preview does not have to be long. Even a few minutes of Spanish-language background before an English reading can make a real difference in how much a newcomer is able to follow. For long-term ELs, an oral Spanish preview or review with a partner is often more useful than a written Spanish text.

Strategic pairing

Seating Spanish speakers together "so they can help each other" is a start, but **strategic** pairing is more intentional. Consider each student's English level, Spanish level, content knowledge, and personality.

Pairing	When it works well
Newcomer + bilingual student (strong in both languages)	The bilingual student can clarify directions and key ideas in Spanish. Rotate who serves this role so no one becomes the class translator (see Chapter 10).
Two Spanish-dominant students	Rich content discussion in Spanish; pair them with strong frames and visuals for the English step.
Progressing LTEL + Progressing LTEL	Talk in Spanish, push each other in English writing; good for peer revision with a checklist.
LTEL + fluent English speaker	Models academic English; works best with structured roles (e.g., "Speaker 1 explains, Speaker 2 restates").

- **Give roles.** "Partner A explains the steps; Partner B checks with the word wall." Roles prevent one student from doing all the work.
- **Change partners regularly**, every unit or every few weeks.
- **Ask students.** Some newcomers prefer a quiet partner; some LTELs prefer not to always be grouped by language. A quick private check-in respects their preferences.
- **Remember Indigenous-language speakers.** If two students share a language like Mam or K'iche', that may be the strongest pairing of all.

Bilingual sentence frames

Sentence frames give students the academic structure they need to put their ideas into English. Bilingual frames show the English and Spanish side by side, helping newcomers understand what the frame means and helping LTELs see how the two languages map onto each other.

English frame	Spanish version
I think ___ because ___.	Creo que ___ porque ___.
I agree with ___ because ___.	Estoy de acuerdo con ___ porque ___.
I disagree with ___ because ___.	No estoy de acuerdo con ___ porque ___.
The evidence shows that ___.	La evidencia muestra que ___.
According to the text, ___.	Según el texto, ___.
First, ___. Then, ___. Finally, ___.	Primero, ___. Luego, ___. Finalmente, ___.
___ is similar to ___ because ___.	___ es similar a ___ porque ___.
___ is different from ___ because ___.	___ es diferente de ___ porque ___.

English frame	Spanish version
One cause of ___ was ___.	Una causa de ___ fue ___.
As a result, ___.	Como resultado, ___.
I predict that ___.	Predigo que ___.
My hypothesis is that if ___, then ___.	Mi hipótesis es que si ___, entonces ___.
The slope is ___, which means ___.	La pendiente es ___, lo que significa que ___.
The author uses ___ to show ___.	El autor usa ___ para mostrar ___.
This primary source shows that ___.	Esta fuente primaria muestra que ___.
What does ___ mean?	¿Qué significa ___?
Can you repeat that, please?	¿Puedes repetirlo, por favor?
I don't understand ___.	No entiendo ___.

TIP · **Make frames work harder**

- Post 3–4 frames per task, not 20.
- For **Emerging** students, provide the full frame. For **Progressing** students, provide a sentence starter and a word bank, then fade the support.
- Underline the academic "glue" words—*because*, *according to*, *as a result*—and teach them explicitly.

PAUSE & REFLECT · **Questions for reflection**

1. Where in your next lesson could students talk in Spanish *before* they write in English?
2. Which pairings in your class are working now? Which ones are not, and why?
3. Which three sentence frames would most improve the writing in your subject?

CHAPTER 6

Translation Tools, Used Well

Helpful servants, unreliable masters

What translation tools are good for

Free tools such as Google Translate, Microsoft Translator, and the translation feature in Microsoft's Immersive Reader can be genuinely useful—**when used for the right purpose**. Good uses include:

- **Checking the meaning of a single word or short phrase**, especially a non-cognate term.
- **Giving a newcomer the gist** of directions or a short passage so they can follow along.
- **Making a quick Spanish preview** of the main idea (have it checked if possible).
- **Live conversation support** with a newcomer when no bilingual adult is available—for example, to ask how they are doing or explain a schedule change.
- **Letting students check their own English writing** by translating it *back* into Spanish to see whether it says what they meant.

Where they fall short

- **Academic and technical terms.** Tools sometimes choose the everyday meaning of a word over the subject-specific one. A tool might translate *cell* incorrectly in context, or translate *mean* (average) as *significar*.
- **Idioms and figurative language.** "Break the ice" or "the bottom line" rarely translate well—which matters a lot in ELA.
- **Regional variation.** Spanish varies by country. Words for everyday things (a car is *carro* in much of Latin America and *coche* in Spain; a board may be *pizarrón* or *pizarra*) differ, and some words that are harmless in one country are rude in another.
- **Tone and sensitive topics.** Machine translation can sound cold, overly formal, or simply wrong in messages about discipline, grades, health, or family concerns.

> CAUTION · **Protect student privacy**
>
> Do not paste student names, grades, IEP or 504 information, or other personal details into a free public translation tool. Follow district guidance on approved tools. For important family communication, use a qualified interpreter or translator (see Chapter 9).

A good-practice checklist

- **Short in, short out.** Translate a sentence or a paragraph, not a whole chapter.
- **Write clear English first.** Short sentences, no idioms, specific nouns. Tools translate plain English much better.
- **Check key terms.** Ask a bilingual colleague, the ENL teacher, or a strong bilingual student (occasionally, not constantly) to look at important materials.

- **Keep the English beside the Spanish.** Bilingual handouts, not Spanish-only handouts, keep English input in front of students.
- **Teach students to use tools strategically.** Model when a tool helps (a single unfamiliar word) and when it hurts (translating an entire essay, which skips the learning and may count as academic dishonesty).

Teaching students to use translation as a learning tool

Instead of...	Try...
Translating the whole reading	Read the English first; translate only 3–5 words you can't figure out from context or cognates.
Writing in Spanish and translating to English	Plan in Spanish, write in English, then use the tool to check whether the English says what you meant.
Copying a translated answer	Translate the question, discuss with a partner, and answer in your own words.
Relying on the tool for every word	Keep a personal glossary of words you looked up so you don't have to look them up again.

PAUSE & REFLECT · **Questions for reflection**

1. When have you seen students use translation tools in your class? Was it helping their learning or replacing it?
2. What is one class document (syllabus, lab safety rules, unit overview) that would benefit from a carefully checked Spanish version?
3. How will you teach students the difference between using a tool to learn and using it to avoid learning?

CHAPTER 7

Honoring Spanish in Assessment

Measuring what students know, not only how much English they have

Start with one question: what am I measuring?

Every assessment measures something. If a chemistry quiz is supposed to measure whether students understand balancing equations, but a student fails because they could not read the English directions, the quiz measured English reading—not chemistry. Before you decide whether Spanish has a place in an assessment, ask:

- **Is this assessment measuring content knowledge** (for example, understanding of cell structure, solving linear equations, causes of the Civil War)?
- **Or is it measuring English language skills** (for example, writing a well-organized English argument, which is an ELA standard)?

When the target is content, Spanish can often be part of how students show what they know. When the target is English writing, the final product should be in English—but Spanish can still support the planning.

Practical ways to honor Spanish

Strategy	How it works
Bilingual directions	Provide directions in English with a checked Spanish version underneath. The content questions stay in English.
Spanish planning space	Include a box labeled "Plan here in any language / Planea aquí en cualquier idioma." Grade only the final answer.
Glossary or word-to-word dictionary	Allow students to use their personal bilingual glossary or a word-to-word (not definition) dictionary. Many states allow word-to-word dictionaries as an EL testing accommodation; ask the ENL teacher what is approved for state tests.
Oral explanation in Spanish	For newcomers, allow a short oral explanation in Spanish, recorded or given to a bilingual staff member, to demonstrate understanding of a concept.
Credit for content in mixed-language answers	If a newcomer's science answer includes Spanish words (*"The plant uses luz to make glucosa"*), give credit for the correct concept, then teach the English words.
Visual and performance tasks	Diagrams, labeled drawings, graphs, models, and demonstrations let students show understanding with less dependence on English.
Separate rubric rows	Score content and language separately, so a student with strong understanding but developing English gets accurate feedback on both.

Long-term ELs and assessment

For long-term ELs, the goal is to **reduce reliance on Spanish over time** in final products while keeping it available for thinking. Many LTELs are close to exiting EL status, and growth in academic English writing is what gets them there. A good balance:

- Spanish for discussion, brainstorming, and planning—always welcome.
- English for final written responses, with frames that fade as the year goes on.

- Feedback that names specific English language goals ("Next time, use *because* and *as a result* to connect your evidence").

Newcomers and assessment

For newcomers, especially in their first months, focus on **access and evidence of learning**:

- Grade content knowledge separately from English.
- Accept Spanish responses on content checks when you have a way to understand them (a colleague, the ENL teacher, or a carefully used translation tool).
- Track small wins in English: labeling a diagram, using three key terms, writing a sentence with a frame.
- Coordinate with the ENL teacher on grading policies so students are not penalized for being new to English.

CAUTION · **Stay within testing rules**

Classroom assessment is flexible; state and district assessments are not. Accommodations for state tests are set by the Mississippi Department of Education and documented in each student's EL plan. Ideally, students should practice in class with the same supports they will be allowed on state tests. When in doubt, check with the ENL teacher or the school test coordinator.

PAUSE & REFLECT · **Questions for reflection**

1. Pick one recent assessment. Did it measure content, English, or both? Would a newcomer have been able to show what they know?
2. Where could you add a "plan in any language" box to an existing test or project?
3. How might separate content and language rubric rows change the feedback you give?

CHAPTER 8

A Teacher's Spanish Phrase Bank

Classroom directions, check-ins, and encouragement

Why a little Spanish goes a long way

You do not need to be fluent. A teacher who greets a newcomer with "¡Bienvenido!", gives a direction in simple Spanish, or says "¡Buen trabajo!" sends a powerful message: *I see you, and your language is welcome here.* Students are usually delighted—and patient—when a teacher tries. Let them correct your pronunciation; it turns them into experts.

SPANISH CORNER · **Pronunciation in one minute**

- **Vowels are short and consistent:** *a* (ah), *e* (eh), *i* (ee), *o* (oh), *u* (oo).
- **h** is silent: *hola* = OH-lah.
- **j** (and **g** before *e* or *i*) sounds like a strong English h: *jugar*, *gente*.
- **ll** and **y** usually sound like English y: *llamar*, *yo*.
- **ñ** sounds like "ny" in *canyon*: *español*.
- **Stress:** words ending in a vowel, *n*, or *s* are stressed on the second-to-last syllable (*cuaderno*); other words on the last syllable (*papel*). A written accent overrides the rule (*página*, *lápiz*).

Tú or ustedes?

Spanish has different verb forms for talking to **one** student (informal *tú*) and to the **whole class** (*ustedes*, used throughout Latin America). With parents and other adults, use the respectful *usted*. The table below gives both student forms.

Classroom directions

English	To one student (tú)	To the class (ustedes)
Sit down, please.	Siéntate, por favor.	Siéntense, por favor.
Listen, please.	Escucha, por favor.	Escuchen, por favor.
Look at the board.	Mira el pizarrón.	Miren el pizarrón.
Pay attention.	Pon atención.	Pongan atención.
Take out your notebook.	Saca tu cuaderno.	Saquen sus cuadernos.
Open your book to page ___.	Abre tu libro en la página ___.	Abran sus libros en la página ___.
Read the directions.	Lee las instrucciones.	Lean las instrucciones.
Write your name.	Escribe tu nombre.	Escriban su nombre.
Raise your hand.	Levanta la mano.	Levanten la mano.
Work with a partner.	Trabaja con un compañero.	Trabajen en parejas.
Show me.	Muéstrame.	Muéstrenme.

English	To one student (tú)	To the class (ustedes)
Wait a moment.	Espera un momento.	Esperen un momento.
You have five minutes.	Tienes cinco minutos.	Tienen cinco minutos.
Put your things away.	Guarda tus cosas.	Guarden sus cosas.
Turn in your work.	Entrega tu trabajo.	Entreguen su trabajo.
Come with me.	Ven conmigo.	Vengan conmigo.
Let's begin.	Vamos a empezar.	Vamos a empezar.

Compañero refers to a male partner or a partner in general; *compañera* refers to a female partner. *Pizarrón* is common in Mexico and Central America; *pizarra* is also widely understood.

Supporting language use

English	Spanish
You can talk in Spanish with your partner, then write in English.	Puedes hablar en español con tu compañero y luego escribir en inglés.
You can say it in Spanish first.	Puedes decirlo primero en español.
Now say it in English, please.	Ahora dilo en inglés, por favor.
Is this word similar in Spanish?	¿Esta palabra se parece a una palabra en español?
How do you say ___ in Spanish?	¿Cómo se dice ___ en español?
What does ___ mean?	¿Qué significa ___?
Use the word wall.	Usa el muro de palabras.

Checking in

English	Spanish
Welcome!	¡Bienvenido! (to a boy) / ¡Bienvenida! (to a girl)
I'm glad you're here.	Me alegra que estés aquí.
What's your name?	¿Cómo te llamas?
How do you pronounce your name?	¿Cómo se pronuncia tu nombre?
How are you?	¿Cómo estás?
Do you need help?	¿Necesitas ayuda?
What do you need?	¿Qué necesitas?
What do you have to do now?	¿Qué tienes que hacer ahora?
Show me the part you don't understand.	Muéstrame la parte que no entiendes.
Can you explain it to me?	¿Me lo puedes explicar?
Are you okay?	¿Estás bien?

Encouragement

English	Spanish
Very good! / Excellent!	¡Muy bien! / ¡Excelente!
Great work!	¡Buen trabajo!
Great idea!	¡Qué buena idea!
Keep it up!	¡Sigue así!
You can do it!	¡Tú puedes!
Almost! Try again.	¡Casi! Inténtalo otra vez.
Don't worry.	No te preocupes.
Mistakes help us learn.	Los errores nos ayudan a aprender.
You're improving a lot.	Estás mejorando mucho.
Thank you for sharing.	Gracias por compartir.
Your Spanish is a strength.	Tu español es una fortaleza.
I'm proud of you.	Estoy orgulloso de ti. (male speaker) / Estoy orgullosa de ti. (female speaker)

TIP · **Start small**

Pick **three** phrases this week—a greeting, one direction, and one encouragement—and use them every day. Add three more next week. By the end of the semester, you will have a working classroom vocabulary.

PAUSE & REFLECT · **Questions for reflection**

1. Which three phrases will you start using this week?
2. How will you invite students to help you with pronunciation without putting anyone on the spot?
3. How might hearing their teacher attempt Spanish affect a newcomer's first week? A long-term EL's?

CHAPTER 9

Partnering with Families

Communication, trust, and funds of knowledge

Families are partners, not an audience

Spanish-speaking families care deeply about their children's education. But when schools communicate only in English, schedule meetings at times families cannot attend, or create spaces that feel unwelcoming, families' absence can be misread as a lack of interest. Moll and colleagues (1992) showed that when teachers approach families as holders of knowledge—not only as recipients of information—relationships and lessons both change.

Your responsibilities

The 2015 joint guidance from the U.S. Departments of Justice and Education reminds schools that they must communicate with parents who have limited English proficiency in a language they can understand, about any program, service, or activity that is called to the attention of parents who are proficient in English. The guidance also cautions schools against relying on students, siblings, friends, or untrained staff to interpret for parents.

> CAUTION · **Don't use students as interpreters for family conferences**
>
> It may be convenient to ask a student to interpret during a parent conference, but it puts the student in an unfair position—especially if the topic is grades, behavior, or attendance. Request a qualified interpreter through the front office or the ENL program, and plan ahead.

> CAUTION · **Never ask about immigration status**
>
> In *Plyler v. Doe* (1982), the U.S. Supreme Court held that states cannot deny children a free public education based on immigration status. Teachers should not ask students or families about immigration status, and should avoid questions that could be heard that way.

Practical steps

- **Ask each family's preferred language** for written and spoken communication, and record it.
- **Send key messages in Spanish and English.** Use district-approved translation services for important documents. For quick, routine messages, a family-messaging app with built-in translation (such as TalkingPoints, if your district uses it) can help.
- **Keep messages short and clear.** Simple English translates more accurately.
- **Share good news**, not only problems. A short positive message in Spanish builds trust fast.
- **Invite family expertise.** A parent who works in construction, cooks professionally, farms, or runs a business may have knowledge that connects directly to your curriculum—and may be willing to share it with your class, in Spanish, with a student or staff interpreter supporting.
- **Be flexible about time and format.** Phone calls, short video calls, or meetings before or after work hours may be easier for families with demanding schedules.

Phrases for families (formal *usted*)

English	Spanish
Hello, I'm ___, your son's / daughter's ___ teacher.	Hola, soy ___, maestro/maestra de ___ de su hijo / hija.
Nice to meet you.	Mucho gusto.
Thank you for coming.	Gracias por venir.
One moment, please. I'll get an interpreter.	Un momento, por favor. Voy a buscar un intérprete.
Your son / daughter works very hard.	Su hijo / hija trabaja mucho.
Your son / daughter is doing well in class.	A su hijo / hija le va bien en la clase.
What is the best way to contact you?	¿Cuál es la mejor manera de comunicarme con usted?
Thank you for your support.	Gracias por su apoyo.

TRY THIS · **A positive-postcard routine**

Each week, send one short positive message home in Spanish and English to a different family. For example: *"Hoy ___ explicó muy bien su respuesta en clase. ¡Gracias por su apoyo!"* (Today ___ explained their answer very well in class. Thank you for your support!) Have a bilingual colleague check your template once; then reuse it.

PAUSE & REFLECT · **Questions for reflection**

1. How do you currently find out a family's preferred language? Where is it recorded?
2. When did you last contact a Spanish-speaking family with good news?
3. What family expertise could connect to an upcoming unit?

CHAPTER 10

Common Pitfalls

And what to do instead

Even teachers with the best intentions can fall into habits that undercut students' learning or dignity. Here are the most common ones, with better alternatives.

Pitfall	What to do instead
Making the same bilingual student the class translator. It interrupts their own learning, adds pressure, and can feel like an unpaid job.	Rotate partners. Use bilingual materials, visuals, and translation tools for routine needs. Thank helpers and ask privately whether they are comfortable helping.
Translating everything. Spanish-only handouts and fully translated texts remove the English input students need to grow.	Keep English and Spanish side by side. Translate directions and key ideas, not entire texts. Use Spanish to preview and review, and English for the main lesson.
Assuming every Hispanic student speaks Spanish—or is an English learner.	Many Hispanic students are English-dominant or fully bilingual; some speak an Indigenous language. Ask, and check EL status with the ENL teacher.
Assuming Spanish speakers can read academic Spanish.	Many long-term ELs were schooled only in English. Use oral Spanish for them unless they tell you otherwise.
"English only" rules or punishing Spanish.	Set expectations about *when* and *why* to use each language ("Talk in any language, write in English"). Redirect off-task talk the same way you would in English.
Using Spanish only for discipline.	Make sure the Spanish students hear from you is mostly welcoming, instructional, and encouraging.
Lowering expectations. Giving English learners easier content instead of support.	Keep grade-level content and add scaffolds: frames, glossaries, visuals, previews, and structured talk.
Letting Spanish replace English output for LTELs.	Spanish for thinking; English for the final product. Fade supports over time.
Mispronouncing or anglicizing names.	Ask students how to pronounce their names, practice, and get it right. Names carry identity.
Treating "Spanish" as one thing.	Vocabulary and expressions vary by country. When students use different words for the same thing, treat it as an interesting discussion, not an error.
Leaving newcomers silent in the back.	Give a buddy, a seat near the front, a bilingual glossary, visuals, and a clear daily routine. Check in by name every day.

TIP · **The two-question test**

When you are not sure whether a use of Spanish is helping, ask yourself:

- **Is it helping the student understand the content?**
- **Is it moving the student toward stronger English?**

If the answer to both is no, adjust. If the answer to either is yes, it is probably a good use.

PAUSE & REFLECT · **Questions for reflection**

1. Which pitfall have you seen most often in your own classroom or school?
2. Who in your classes might be serving as an unofficial translator? How could you lighten that load?
3. How will you explain your classroom's language expectations to students on the first day of a new unit?

CHAPTER 11

Lesson Snapshots

One sample lesson for each core subject

Each snapshot shows how the strategies in this guide fit into an ordinary 50–55 minute class period. They are not scripts. Borrow the structure, swap in your own content, and adjust the supports for the students in front of you.

LESSON SNAPSHOT

Snapshot: Algebra I

Slope as a Rate of Change

Course	Algebra I (grades 9–10)
Content objective	Students will interpret the slope of a linear function as a rate of change in a real-world context.
Language objective	Students will explain the meaning of slope orally and in writing using the frame "The slope is ___, which means ___."
Cognates	linear / lineal · function / función · constant / constante · variable / variable
Pre-teach	slope = *pendiente* · rate of change = *tasa de cambio* · per = *por*

1. **Preview in Spanish (5 min).** Show the prompt on the board in English and Spanish: *A landscaping business charges a $40 visit fee plus $25 per hour. / Un negocio de jardinería cobra $40 por la visita más $25 por hora.* Partners discuss in any language: "How much would 1, 2, and 3 hours cost?"
2. **Funds-of-knowledge hook (3 min).** Ask: "Does anyone in your family get paid by the hour or by the job?" Accept answers in any language.
3. **View in English (15 min).** Build a table and graph together. Point to *slope* and *pendiente* on the word wall. Model: "The slope is 25, which means the cost goes up $25 for every hour."
4. **Partner practice (12 min).** Pairs complete two more contexts (a phone plan and a car wash fundraiser). Partner A explains the slope; Partner B checks the frame. Talk can be in Spanish; written answers are in English.
5. **Review (5 min).** Pairs summarize in Spanish what slope means, then share one English sentence with the class.
6. **Exit ticket (5 min).** "In y = 12x + 30, what does 12 mean if x is the number of tickets sold?" Use the frame.

Newcomers	Bilingual problem cards; a bilingual partner; answer the exit ticket with the frame and a labeled graph. Accept some Spanish words in the explanation.
Long-term ELs	Full frame for the first problem only, then a starter ("The slope means...") for the rest. Require the words *rate* and *per*.
Watch for	Students writing 3,5 for 3.5 (see Chapter 3). The word *mean* (average) vs. *mean* (signify).

LESSON SNAPSHOT

Snapshot: Biology

Photosynthesis

Course	Biology I (grades 9–10)
Content objective	Students will describe the inputs and outputs of photosynthesis and explain where it occurs in the cell.
Language objective	Students will write a cause-and-effect explanation using *because* and *as a result*.
Cognates	photosynthesis / fotosíntesis · chloroplast / cloroplasto · energy / energía · glucose / glucosa · carbon dioxide / dióxido de carbono · oxygen / oxígeno
False cognate	cell = *célula* (not *celda*)

1. **Preview in Spanish (5 min).** Students watch a short Spanish-language video clip on photosynthesis (preview it yourself; ask the ENL teacher for a recommendation) or read a five-sentence Spanish summary. Same-language groups brainstorm: "¿Qué necesitan las plantas para vivir?" (What do plants need to live?)
2. **Cognate hunt (5 min).** Pairs highlight cognates in the English lab handout and add three to the word wall.
3. **View in English (15 min).** Run a leaf-disk or *Elodea* demonstration. Label a diagram together: light, water, carbon dioxide in; glucose and oxygen out.
4. **Talk → Plan → Write (15 min).** Partners discuss in any language: "What would happen to a plant kept in the dark? Why?" Then each student writes in English: "Because ___, the plant ___. As a result, ___."
5. **Review (5 min).** Pairs explain the diagram to each other in Spanish, then one partner explains it in English to the class.

Newcomers	Bilingual labeled diagram; allow labels in both languages; credit correct concepts even with some Spanish words.
Long-term ELs	Push for precise academic English: *produces*, *releases*, *absorbs*. Offer a word bank rather than a full frame.
Funds of knowledge	Invite students whose families garden or farm to share what plants need—an authentic connection to light and water.

LESSON SNAPSHOT

Snapshot: U.S. History

Freedom Summer, 1964

Course	U.S. History (grade 11)
Content objective	Students will analyze a primary source to explain the goals and obstacles of the 1964 Freedom Summer voter registration campaign in Mississippi.
Language objective	Students will make a claim about a primary source and support it with evidence using "This primary source shows that ___ because ___."
Cognates	discrimination / discriminación · democracy / democracia · movement / movimiento · registration / registro · testimony / testimonio · organize / organizar
Pre-teach	civil rights = *derechos civiles* · right to vote = *derecho al voto* · primary source = *fuente primaria*

1. **Preview in Spanish (5 min).** Groups discuss: "¿Por qué es importante votar? ¿Qué pasa si alguien no puede votar?" (Why is voting important? What happens if someone can't vote?) Students report one idea in English.
2. **Local connection (3 min).** Remind students that this history happened in Mississippi. Ask: "What do you already know about the Civil Rights Movement?" Some students may connect to struggles for rights in their families' home countries—welcome those connections.
3. **View in English (15 min).** Introduce Freedom Summer and Fannie Lou Hamer. Play a short excerpt of her 1964 testimony before the Credentials Committee of the Democratic National Convention, with English captions on screen and an English transcript excerpt.
4. **Primary-source analysis (15 min).** Pairs read the excerpt with a bilingual glossary of key terms. They discuss in any language: "What obstacles did she face? What did she want?" Then each student writes a claim in English using the frame.
5. **Review (5 min).** Pairs summarize in Spanish, then share claims in English.

Newcomers	Provide a checked Spanish summary of the excerpt alongside the English; allow a labeled timeline or drawing as part of the response.
Long-term ELs	Focus on evidence language: *according to*, *she states that*, *this suggests*. Peer-check with a short rubric.
Sensitivity	Discussions of rights and voting can touch on immigration or citizenship. Keep the focus on the history; never ask about students' or families' status.

LESSON SNAPSHOT

Snapshot: English II

Writing an Argument

Course	English II (grade 10)
Content objective	Students will write an argument paragraph with a claim, evidence, and reasoning, and address a counterclaim.
Language objective	Students will use transition words (*however*, *for example*, *therefore*) to connect claims and evidence.
Cognates	evidence / evidencia · persuasive / persuasivo · conclusion / conclusión · paragraph / párrafo · counterargument / contraargumento
False cognate	argument / *argumento* (in Spanish literature class, *argumento* often means the **plot**)

1. **Preview in Spanish (7 min).** Prompt: "Should all high school students be required to learn a second language? / ¿Todos los estudiantes de secundaria deberían estar obligados a aprender un segundo idioma?" Partners debate in any language and list reasons on both sides.
2. **False-cognate moment (3 min).** Show *argument / argumento* and *discussion / discusión*. Ask Spanish speakers to explain the difference—students become the experts.
3. **View in English (12 min).** Model a strong argument paragraph. Color-code claim, evidence, reasoning, and counterclaim. Highlight transitions.
4. **Plan in any language (8 min).** Students fill out a graphic organizer; the planning column says *"Plan in any language / Planea en cualquier idioma."*
5. **Write in English (15 min).** Students write their paragraph using frames: "I believe ___ because ___. For example, ___. Some people argue ___; however, ___."
6. **Review (5 min).** Partners read each other's paragraphs and check for a claim, evidence, and one transition.

Newcomers	Bilingual frames; may write a shorter paragraph or a set of strong sentences; may use a bilingual glossary.
Long-term ELs	Expect a full paragraph; fade frames after the claim sentence; conference on one language goal.
Bonus text	Pair the writing with a short text by a bilingual author who writes about language and identity, chosen with the ENL teacher.

CHAPTER 12

Putting It into Practice

A 30-day plan and questions for reflection

Start with one move

You do not need to do everything in this guide at once. Choose one strategy, use it consistently for a few weeks, watch what happens, and then add another. Small, consistent moves add up.

Week	Focus
Week 1	Learn every student's name and how to pronounce it. Use three Spanish phrases daily. Give the language survey from Chapter 2.
Week 2	Add a bilingual word wall for your current unit. Teach one cognate pattern. Introduce the rule "Talk in any language, write in English."
Week 3	Try one Preview-View-Review lesson. Post three bilingual sentence frames. Plan strategic pairs.
Week 4	Add a "plan in any language" box to an assessment. Send one positive message home in Spanish. Meet with the ENL teacher to reflect.

Reflection questions for teachers

Use these on your own, with a colleague, or in a PLC.

About your beliefs

- What did you believe about using students' home languages before reading this guide? What do you believe now?
- How does your classroom show students that their language and culture are valued?

About your students

- Which of your students are long-term ELs, and which are newcomers? What does each group need from you?
- What do you know about your students' lives, interests, and families? What could you learn?

About your practice

- Which strategy from this guide fits most naturally with how you already teach?
- Where in your lessons do students currently have to think, talk, and write all in English at once? Where could Spanish lighten that load?
- How will you hold students accountable for English output while welcoming Spanish for thinking?

About evidence

- What will you look for to know whether a strategy is working (participation, quality of writing, quiz results, student confidence)?
- How will you ask students for feedback on what helps them?

About collaboration

- Who can help you—the ENL teacher, bilingual staff, colleagues in your department, families?
- What is one thing you would like to plan with the ENL teacher this semester?

QUICK REFERENCE

Spanish in the Content Classroom: One-Page Guide

10 MOVES THAT WORK

- **Say it out loud:** "Think and talk in any language; write in English."
- **Teach cognates:** -tion/-ción, -ty/-dad, -ous/-oso, -ly/-mente, s→es.
- **Flag false cognates:** *argumento*, *carácter*, *realizar*, *actual*, *éxito*, *celda*, *billón*.
- **Bilingual word wall:** 10–20 unit words, two colors, visuals.
- **Student glossaries:** term · Spanish · own explanation · picture.
- **Preview–View–Review:** Spanish preview → English lesson → Spanish review → English output.
- **Strategic pairs:** plan by English level, Spanish level, personality; rotate.
- **Bilingual sentence frames:** 3–4 per task; fade over time.
- **Translation tools:** words and short phrases, not whole texts; no student data.
- **Assess content fairly:** bilingual directions, "plan in any language" box, separate rubric rows.

KNOW YOUR LEARNERS

- **Long-term ELs:** fluent-sounding, strong oral Spanish, academic literacy still developing in both languages. Use Spanish for **talk**, push English **writing**.
- **Newcomers:** need belonging, routines, a buddy, Spanish previews and glossaries; credit content shown in Spanish.
- **Ask, don't assume:** some students speak an Indigenous language; not all Hispanic students are ELs.

AVOID

- Making one student the permanent translator
- Translating everything (keep English beside Spanish)
- "English only" rules or Spanish used only for discipline
- Students as interpreters at family conferences
- Asking about immigration status

DIRECTIONS (CLASS / ONE STUDENT)

- Listen, please. — *Escuchen / Escucha, por favor.*
- Take out your notebook. — *Saquen sus cuadernos / Saca tu cuaderno.*
- Work with a partner. — *Trabajen en parejas / Trabaja con un compañero.*
- Read the directions. — *Lean / Lee las instrucciones.*
- You have five minutes. — *Tienen / Tienes cinco minutos.*
- Talk in Spanish, then write in English. — *Hablen en español y luego escriban en inglés.*

CHECK-INS

- Welcome! — *¡Bienvenido! / ¡Bienvenida!*
- Do you need help? — *¿Necesitas ayuda?*
- What do you have to do now? — *¿Qué tienes que hacer ahora?*
- How do you pronounce your name? — *¿Cómo se pronuncia tu nombre?*

ENCOURAGEMENT

- *¡Muy bien!* · *¡Buen trabajo!* · *¡Sigue así!* · *¡Tú puedes!*
- Almost! Try again. — *¡Casi! Inténtalo otra vez.*
- Mistakes help us learn. — *Los errores nos ayudan a aprender.*
- Your Spanish is a strength. — *Tu español es una fortaleza.*

POWER FRAMES

- I think ___ because ___. — *Creo que ___ porque ___.*
- The evidence shows that ___. — *La evidencia muestra que ___.*
- According to the text, ___. — *Según el texto, ___.*
- One cause of ___ was ___. — *Una causa de ___ fue ___.*
- I agree / disagree with ___ because ___. — *(No) estoy de acuerdo con ___ porque ___.*

THE TWO-QUESTION TEST

- Is this use of Spanish helping the student **understand the content**? Is it moving them toward **stronger English**? If either is yes, keep it.

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TIP · **Helpful places to look next**

- **ELPA21** (elpa21.org): proficiency level descriptors and score report guides.
- **Colorín Colorado** (colorincolorado.org): free articles on cognates, family engagement, and ELs in content classes.
- **CUNY-NYSIEB** resources on translanguaging for teachers who don't speak students' home languages.
- **Your ENL teacher**: student data, accommodations, materials, and co-planning.

APPENDIX

Planning Tools

Unit planning checklist

Before starting a unit, check off what you have ready:

- ☐ 10–20 key vocabulary words, sorted into cognates, false cognates, and non-cognates
- ☐ Bilingual word wall cards (with visuals)
- ☐ A Spanish preview (video, summary, or discussion prompt)
- ☐ 3–4 bilingual sentence frames matched to the unit's main writing task
- ☐ Strategic partner list (updated)
- ☐ Bilingual directions for the unit assessment, plus a "plan in any language" box
- ☐ One funds-of-knowledge connection
- ☐ A note to the ENL teacher about upcoming vocabulary and assessments

Strategic pairing planner

Student	ELPA21 level	Spanish strength (oral / literacy)	LTEL or newcomer?	Good partner(s)

Bilingual glossary template

English term	Español	My explanation (any language)	Picture / example